

Disillusion and desertion

The quality of Union troops was diluted in the last years of the war. The proud if war-weary volunteers who had fought since 1861 were often contemptuous of the mercenary “bounty men” and substitutes raked in from 1863 onward—Private Frank Wilkeson dismissed them as “conscienceless and cowardly scoundrels.” Desertion rates were always high, men slinking away, discouraged by army life or needing to cope with difficulties at home. But those who joined up for a lump sum payment were notorious for disappearing. Grant complained in September 1864 that: “The men we have been getting in this way almost all desert.” Yet Union troops always proved tough fighters when it mattered. There was no questioning the courage and fighting spirit of the soldiers in blue.